

Wolves in sheep's clothing

WE LIVE IN AN AGE WHERE FACTS ARE

OPINIONS, or opinions facts, and we also have alternative facts... whatever those are. We are the most opinionated society that has ever lived, and we have biases galore, which we feed on a daily basis. Our egos are big, our voices loud (in CAPS online), our convictions courageous; despite our knowledge lacking depth, a total inability to self-reflect, and no desire to hear a counter argument, let alone be capable of changing our minds. We all fancy ourselves to be leaders, and yet are all just sheep. And who are the shepherds? These people we call social media influencers. They're more wolves than shepherds though.

There used to be a time when I despised the word "evangelist" the most (read the August 2009 column). I have since demoted evangelists to second place, and I now hate the term "influencer" the most. This time it has much less to do with the word itself, and much more to do with what so-called influencers do. And yes, as much as I hate the fact that our Digit Squad promotion includes that word, I'm told we have to market it using terms everyone understands.

I'm not an instagrammer. I guess I'm too old to be one, and too in love with my PC. My first instinct is not to pull out my phone and capture a moment. Neither is my goal in life to be followed and liked, or hearted, or whatever it is called on instagram. My job, however, needs me to be aware of all that happens in the tech world, and, sadly, Instagram is a part of that.

Instagram is a business. Pure and simple. No one popular on instagram is on there to enjoy themselves, or to pointlessly share anything. It's all crafted and strategically positioned to sell you stuff. First you're sold the idea of the user and whatever it is they claim to stand for, and then you're sold the stuff the user is trying to hock to you. Sometimes it is discrete and almost subliminal, and sometimes in your face, but it's always there.

Influencers may have started off on YouTube, and are still there, but Instagram is certainly the default home for most of them. However, it's not the platform that I have a problem with, it's the content and the total lack of ethics and regulation.

These days, you cannot launch a mass consumption brand without having very deep pockets and huge budgets to pay off social media influencers. Reports (released by actual

journalists – digit.in/smi-fraud) have suggested that brands pay each influencer between 50k and 70k USD (35 to 50 lakh) per video. Yes. PER VIDEO. And what do they get? Said influencer fawning over their product. As far as I am concerned, that's a bribe. Actually, it's worse, it's more like mafia protection money, because apparently if you launch a new brand or a new product, and don't give an influencer money, they're likely to ignore your product... if you're lucky, that is. Some influencers will go as far as bashing your products as a way of teaching you a lesson.

From simple product placements to all out fawning over products, everything has a price, and influencers are raking in the money, with no regulation whatsoever. Heck, in fact, when influencers are growing their own brand image, and don't have sponsors, they actually just fake it and pretend to be selling products. Why? Because this fools other companies into believing that they're being paid, and also fools users into believing that they're influential enough to be noticed and given free stuff by large companies. All out fraud basically.

While we at Digit are super strict about making sure advertising is clearly demarcated and that it has absolutely no influence on our editorial content, influencers are doing the exact opposite. While we lose advertising revenue every year after our Zero1 Awards – we tell you what the best products of the year were, and not all of our advertisers agree with our results, thinking their product should have won. Chalk it down to being passionate about their own products, but the JFM quarter is our lightest in terms of advertising for that very reason. And yet we do it every year.

The same applies to our reviews, which are conducted under a strict objective test process. It doesn't get us too many fans in the advertising community, and some advertisers have come to expect favourable "reviews" from the average blogger or influencer, for a price. We've even been told by people in the industry that we're too old school, and are passing up crores of rupees every month with our "outdated ideas of morality".

I disagree. Strongly. I'd rather die honest than live on bribes. However, that's up to you, and whether you will accept being led around like sheep by an influencer, or think for yourself and value transparent testing methods. Which is it going to be? 



"I now hate the term "influencer" the most. This time it has much less to do with the word itself, and much more to do with what so-called influencers do."



Liked or hated this column? Let me know at: editor@digit.in
| facebook.com/raaabo
| [@raaabo](https://twitter.com/raaabo)